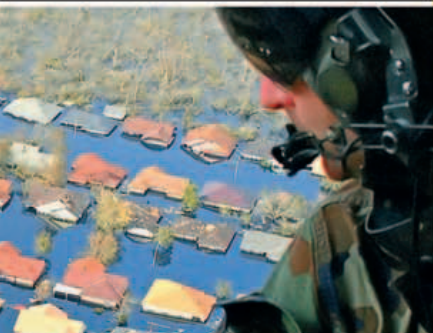


“ FUTURE GENERATIONS MAY WELL ASK THEMSELVES, WHAT WERE OUR PARENTS THINKING? ”

Al Gore, US politician, *An Inconvenient Truth*, 2006



London on July 7. Coordinated **terrorist attacks** struck three underground trains and a double-decker bus, killing 52 people, and injuring several hundred more. The four suicide bombers, all British men, were backed by **al-Qaeda**.

Weeks after the al-Qaeda attack on the London transport system, the **provisional IRA**—the paramilitary wing of the Irish Republican Army—announced it was **ceasing its armed campaign** on July 28. Two months later there was a verification statement from the independent arms decommissioning body that the IRA had put all its weapons beyond use.

The **Kyoto accord** came into force seven years after it was first agreed (see 1997). It aimed to curb the air pollution blamed for global warming. The US, the world's top polluter, did not sign up, as the protocol was not thought to be in the best interest of the American economy.

Hurricane Katrina hit New Orleans in the US, on August 29 causing unprecedented damage. The hurricane also battered large swathes of the Louisiana and Mississippi coastlines, leaving two oil rigs adrift in the Gulf of Mexico and causing destruction estimated at \$26 billion.

YouTube, a video-sharing website, was launched in February and soon grew into one of the most popular websites on the internet. After only a year 100 million videos were being viewed every day.

THE BASQUE SEPARATIST GROUP ETA declared a permanent **ceasefire** on March 22. They aimed to pursue independence for the Basque region through a **democratic process**.

Montenegro became a sovereign state on June 3 after a **referendum** in which just over 55 percent of the populace voted for **independence**. It meant the end of the former Union of Serbia and Montenegro, created only three years earlier from the former Yugoslavia (see 2003).

Iran announced that it had produced the **enriched uranium** needed to make nuclear fuel. It insisted this was for generating nuclear power, but the West was concerned that Iran was making a nuclear bomb.

Power generator

The building of the world's largest hydroelectric installation, the Three Gorges Dam, was completed in 2006, in China.



Another nuclear power, **North Korea**, announced it had tested a **nuclear weapon** on October 9, provoking severe international condemnation.

Construction began on the **Freedom Tower** in New York on April 26. The skyscraper was to replace the twin towers destroyed in the 9/11 attacks (see 2001).

Seven **bombs** exploded on the suburban railway of **Mumbai**, India, on July 11. Over 200 lost their lives. Tension between India and Pakistan increased when evidence suggested that the Pakistani intelligence agency was involved in the attacks.

The **Three Gorges Dam** in China was completed on May 20. At 1.4 miles (2.3km) long, it is one of the world's largest dams, and one of the most controversial public works in modern times. The dam was engineered to prevent flooding along the **Yangtze River**, but had a huge social and ecological impact.



Former prime minister of Pakistan, Benazir Bhutto, campaigning in Karachi before elections.

BULGARIA AND ROMANIA joined the **European Union** on January 1.

They took the membership of the group from 25 to 27 member states.

Direct rule over **Northern Ireland** by London officially ended on May 8. Democratic Unionist Party leader **Ian Paisley** and Sinn Féin's **Martin McGuinness** were sworn in as first and deputy first ministers of the new executive.

Iranian forces captured 15 British sailors on March 23. The sailors were accused of entering Iranian waters and were held prisoner for 11 days.

Nawaz Sharif, former prime minister of Pakistan, returned home from exile in August, vowing

“ I PUT MY LIFE IN DANGER AND CAME HERE BECAUSE I BELIEVE MY COUNTRY TO BE IN DANGER. ”

Benazir Bhutto, Pakistani politician, in a speech shortly before her assassination

iPhone

A new type of multimedia phone, the iPhone connects to the internet via a touch screen. It was launched in January by US technology company Apple.



to end the “dictatorship” of President Musharraf.

Within weeks he was deported to Saudi Arabia.

Another former leader of Pakistan, **Benazir Bhutto**, was assassinated on

December 27 during a political rally. Islamist militants were thought to be responsible.

On December 24, **Nepal** announced that it would abolish its monarchy after elections, which were to be held in 2008. Some parties had refused to serve in government until Nepal became a republic.

A major scientific breakthrough was made when the first **artificial sperm** was created in April. It was grown from human bone marrow samples in a laboratory in Newcastle, England.

The mysterious **dark matter** that makes up a quarter of the universe was revealed in May by a 3D map made by the **Hubble telescope**. It helped explain how the universe was formed.

The final book in the **Harry Potter** series by J.K. Rowling was released on July. *Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows* became the fastest selling book of all time.

October 8 Earthquake in Kashmir, India, kills around 75,000

October–November Civil unrest in Paris suburbs in France

October 19 trial of Saddam Hussein begins in Iraq

November 23 Ellen Johnson Sirleaf elected as first female president of Liberia

December 5 Same-sex marriage becomes legal in UK

January 5 Israeli prime minister, Ariel Sharon, has second stroke

January 26 Hamas wins elections in Palestine

April 27 Construction begins on Freedom Tower, New York

June 3 Montenegro becomes independent

December 10 Death of Augusto Pinochet, former Chilean dictator (b. 1915)

March 22 Basque separatists, ETA, declare permanent ceasefire

April 11 Iran enriches uranium

May 20 Three Gorges Dam completed in China

July 11 Bomb explosions on Mumbai railway in India

October 9 North Korea tests nuclear weapon

December 30 Saddam Hussein sentenced to death

June 29 US company Apple launches iPhone

July 21 Final Harry Potter book published

September British troops withdraw from Basra, Iraq

September 6 Death of Italian opera star Luciano Pavarotti (b. 1935)

October Housing bubble bursts in US

December 27 Benazir Bhutto, former Pakistani prime minister, assassinated (b. 1953)

December 24 Nepal announces plan to abolish monarchy